Developmental Trajectories of Cultural Connectedness and Resilience among Indigenous Youth

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Background

- Resilience is defined as a "dynamic process encompassing positive adaptation" following adversity or trauma (Luthar, Cicchetti, & Becker, 2000)
  - In Indigenous contexts, resilience is understood as a collective and relational process grounded in family, community, culture, and shared systems of meaning (Kirmayer, 2011; Wexler, DiFluvio & Burke, 2009).
- Cultural connectedness is "the degree to which an individual identifies with, integrates into, and feels a sense of belonging to a specific cultural group or heritage" (White & Starzyk, 2022).
  - Connections to language, traditions, spirituality, land, family, and community
  - Has been associated with improved wellbeing among Indigenous youth (Snowshoe et al., 2015).
- Developmental theories of identity formation suggest that cultural identity and belonging may become increasingly salient across adolescence, as youth engage in greater identity exploration and social meaning-making (Phinney, 1989; Umana-Taylor et al., 2009)

Study Aims

1. To explore the relationship between cultural connectedness and resilience in Indigenous adolescents, specifically:

a) if cultural connectedness is associated with resilience

b) whether this relationship varies by age

Method

Participants: Indigenous adolescents between the ages of 12-18 (grades 6 - 11) attending school in a First Nations community in Northern Quebec.

Year	N	Females	mean age (SD)
2016	65	38	14.46 (1.76)
2017	73	40	15.04 (1.72)
2018	60	35	14.58 (1.73)
2019	58	32	14.60 (1.70)

Measures:

Cultural Connectedness Scale (CCS; Snowshoe et al., 2015)

Cultural Identity (α = .86)
- ex. " I have a strong sense of belonging to my [Aboriginal/FNMI] community or Nation."

Tradition (α = .80)
- ex. " I have helped prepare for a cultural ceremony."

Spirituality (α = .71)
- ex. "When I am overwhelmed with my emotions, I look to my [Aboriginal/FNMI] culture for help.

Child and Youth Resilience Measure (CYRM-28; Unger & Liebenberg, 2011)

Individual Resilience (α = .85)
- ex. "Do you strive to finish what you start?"

Caregiver Resilience (α = .82)
- ex. "Do you think your family will always stand by you during difficult times?"

Contextual Resilience (α = .88)
- ex. "Do you know where to go in your community to get help?"

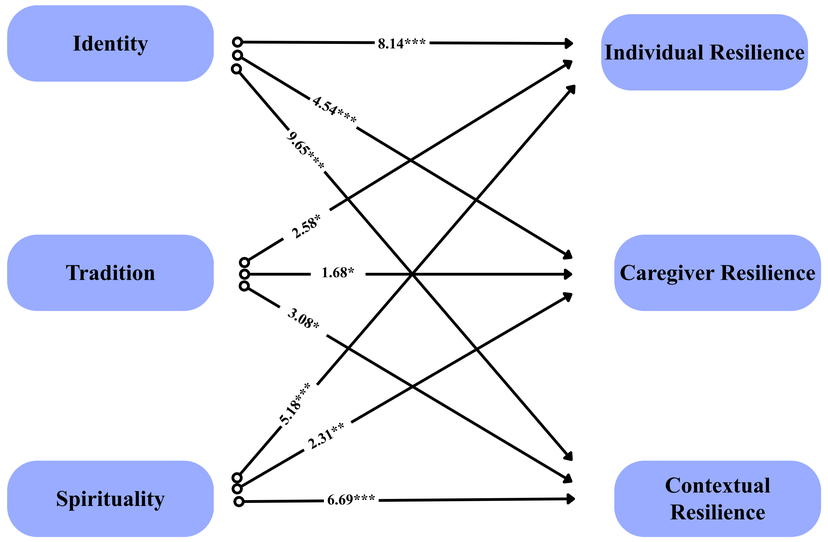
Statistical Analysis: Separate mixed-effects models were used to test whether cultural identity, tradition, and spirituality predicted individual, caregiver, and contextual resilience, and whether these associations varied with age through Age × Cultural Connectedness interactions.

Results

Associations between Cultural Connectedness and Resilience

Figure 1

Main Effect of Cultural Connectedness on Resilience Domains



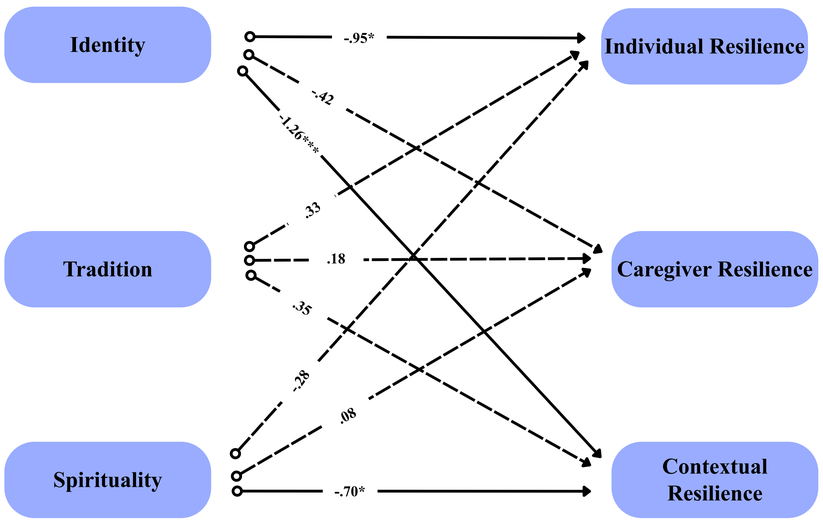
Note. *p < .05, **p < .01, ***p < .001.

- At age 12, stronger cultural connectedness across all cultural domains was associated with higher resilience across all resilience domains.
- Children with strong cultural connectedness consistently demonstrated greater resilience than peers with lower cultural connectedness.

The Influence of Age on Cultural Connectedness and Resilience

Figure 2

Age-Based Interactions between Cultural Connectedness and Resilience Domains

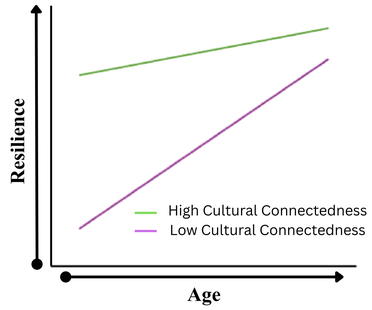


Note. *p < .05, **p < .01, ***p < .001. Dashed arrows indicate non-significant interactions.

These results reflect between-group age differences rather than within-person developmental change over time.

Graph 1

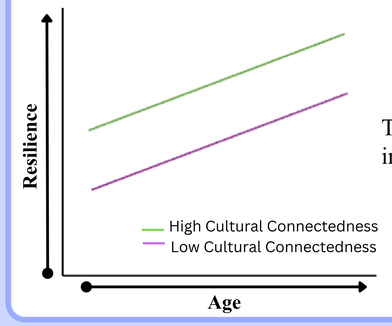
Pattern 1: Significant Age-Based Interactions between Cultural Connectedness and Resilience Domains



This pattern emerged from the interactions between:
(1) Cultural Identity and Individual Resilience
(2) Cultural Identity and Contextual Resilience
(3) Spirituality and Contextual Resilience

Graph 2

Pattern 2: Non-Significant Age-Based Interactions between Cultural Connectedness and Resilience Domains



This pattern was found for all other interactions.

Discussion

- Cultural connectedness emerged as an important promotive factor for resilience among Indigenous youth.
  - Across domains, stronger connections to culture were associated with higher levels of resilience.
  - May provide youth with a stronger sense of belonging, meaning, and support that promotes positive adaptation across multiple areas of life.
- ·Some aspects of cultural connectedness also showed developmental differences across adolescence
  - For domains of cultural identity and spirituality,
    - High levels of cultural connectedness are related with increased resilience regardless of age.
    - Low levels of cultural connectedness are related to decreased resilience specifically in early adolescence.
  - For domains of traditions and spirituality,
    - Higher and lower levels of cultural connectedness are associated with increased resilience.
    - Resilience increases with age for both high and low levels of cultural connectedness.
- Two patterns of developmental trajectories emerged between the domains of cultural connectedness and of resilience.

Scan for references

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